

MAHARASHTRA

SURGICAL STRIKE?

By Dhaval Kulkarni

Maharashtra has some 1,700 of India's 13,000 leopards, the third-highest population of the big cat after Madhya Pradesh (3,421) and Karnataka (1,783). And, in an additional but troubling nuance recorded by the exhaustive report called the 'Status of Leopards, Co-predators and Mega Herbivores in India 2018', around 65 per cent of them live outside protected areas like wildlife sanctuaries, national parks and tiger projects. This presence in human-dominated areas makes them vulnerable. Even in this unregulated state—call it a default to nature—leopards do lend a helping hand to humans by preying on feral cattle and wild boar that raid standing crops of farmers. But the larger frame is that of conflict: since 2017, official lists record 113 people as having been killed in leopard attacks. A solution had to be found one way or the other.

State forests minister Sudhir Mungantiwar says a committee constituted by the forest department to look into mitigating human-leopard conflict is looking into a few options, including this one—sterilisation. Legislators from the affected areas, he adds, are amenable to the idea too. A senior official of the forest department says, "We will see if sterilisation can be done with the existing resources, and if it will be an effective measure." The feasibility study will be completed in a month's time. The prime challenge will be identifying the carnivores prone to attacking humans and capturing them.

Alongside, other ameliorative steps are in the works. The number of 'leopard rescue' teams are being increased, and awareness creation is proceeding apace. This includes practical measures like keeping the village boundaries clean to reduce the proliferation of stray dogs and ensuring effective street lighting. But, as the official notes, the conflict "can only be minimised, not eliminated". The 2018 report tells us why: "Despite their widespread distribution, leopard habitats are being increasingly fragmented, and such small fragmented areas with low wild prey densities cannot harbour a sizeable population." The spillover into "human-dominated landscapes" is inevitable, then, and only a more targeted intervention holds out hope.

Forest officials in neighbouring Gujarat have also proposed the sterilisation of leopards, especially in and around the Gir National Park. Animal birth control measures have been adopted to control the proliferation of other species as well. Himachal Pradesh has had a monkey sterilisation programme since 2007, which it claims helped halve the simian population to 136,000 by 2019. However, Mungantiwar and senior forest officials say permission for this invasive 'scientific management' must come from the Union government. Leopards are covered under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, according them the highest level of protection. The idea

To reduce human-leopard conflict, the Maharashtra forest department may try sterilising the big cats in conflict zones